

Thank You, Have a Nice Day!

By Doran J. Seff

Annual Bomb Threats in the United States:

2009: 1038

2019: 1355

2029: 224,632

The phone rang at Kimber's desk just as she'd just bitten into a Fig Newton, which threw off her whole routine for answering the phone. Should she spit out the Fig Newton? Or finish the Fig Newton, take the requisite 10 seconds to rehydrate her mouth, pick up the phone, apologize for how long it took her to pick up the phone, overshare about the Fig Newton, apologize for oversharing, apologize for over-apologizing, and live in constant fear of the negative YELP review that would inevitably follow.

She spat out the Newton right onto her keyboard. If this was another one of those disgusting prank calls they'd been getting lately, this time she might actually blow up. "Fake Bomb Threats, this is Kimber. How may I help you?... Yes, we can call in a fake bomb threat for you, that's what we do... Sure, we've done lots of schools... Yeah, the website is a little confusing... I know, I've been telling them we should get an app... No, I totally get it, I hated math too... Absolutely, what's the name of the school? ... Thank you, that is very nice of you to

say... Oh, stop it... Alright, I have you down for our SilverStar package at 10:30... Yup, that's 10:30 AM... Well, it's been a pleasure serving you, I'm gonna pass you over to Bill at Billing to get you all closed out... Yep, the guy who works at Billing is named Bill... Haha yes, that is very funny... You too... Thank you. Have a nice day!"

Kimber was playing a very efficient round of minesweeper when she saw her manager, Wayne, strutting down the long hallway to her desk area. Wayne always wore long sleeve button-downs that were off-shades of blue; periwinkle, picotee, bluebonnet, Egyptian, savoy. Today Wayne was blurple. He had fourteen different pairs of corduroy pants, all of which stopped a few centimeters short of his protruding ankles, which he seemed oddly proud of.

"Kimber wimber. Have those jerkholes called you again to say those nasty things?" asked Wayne in his nasally tone.

She shook her head. "No, Wayne, thanks for asking. It's just been a normal day so far."

"Great! That's just jolly-O. Are you still okay to stay a little after hours today to go over your practice BronzeStar Package?" said Wayne, leaning on her desk with one arm, back hunched, making his Adam's apple look like a dull scythe coming to politely slice her open.

"Absolutely, Wayne, that would be great. I know I didn't do everything right, but I'm learning more every time we do it and---"

"Heyyy, no need for that," Wayne interrupted. "You know how much we believe in you here. You're a big-time part of the team, and we're going to do whatever we can to keep you

moving up that little ladder until you're the one calling in the bomb threats. That's the money spot! That's the big leagues! Don't you want a big chair?"

"I think that, yes, I want the---"

"Of course you want the big chair!" said Wayne.

"I think, yeah..."

"And we want you, our only woman, to get a big chair, because we're a company that's thinking ahead. We're a family, and we take care of our woman. Not like we're a caveman company, and we, big men, kill bear, build fire, do bomb threat, and you, woman, you cook, you clean, haha. No. Not that. We want you to shine! Not because we need a woman in a big chair to be compliant with equitable hiring standards, although we do, but because we think that you're a superduperstar!"

"That all sounds...great, Wayne" said Kimber.

Wayne winked with both eyes and shot her with a finger gun, making like he was going back down the hallway, then turned back around.

"I almost forgot. Bill wanted me to ask you to stop making jokes about his name. He doesn't like it. He's an esteemed colleague, not a punchline."

"Alright."

"Rodger, Dodger," said Wayne.

Kimber spent the barren hours between lunch and her training session with Wayne in a stupor that couldn't be clicked into oblivion with minesweeper. The phone scared her. Every time it rang, her heart shuddered because she knew it could be those same people that had

been calling lately, saying those terrible things, and even when it wasn't her heart had missed a step in the dance. She was always playing catch up with her heartbeats. Air was leaking out of her pipes, depositing odd gas pockets around her abdomen. She'd see a 2 in minesweeper with 3 spaces surrounding it and she'd click anyway. Obviously, it would be a bomb, and she'd explode and feel stupid. Then she'd eat another Fig Newton even though she'd overeaten at lunch, and she'd feel that one more thing sinking into her, pulling her skirt that much tighter around her like a polyester noose on her stomach.

She dreaded her practice session with Wayne, where he'd bring in his big chair and break down her pathetic bomb threats again, line-by-line. She didn't know if she could keep holding in how she really felt about his ankles, or his Adam's apple, and she'd have to sit there with all these things building up inside her, along with the gas pockets, plus lunch, plus the Fig Newtons, and be afraid the whole time that she'd inflate with one of those slow farts that sounded like an old door opening and she'd have to excuse herself every two minutes to let one out in the hallway. She'd probably trap the smell with her, so she'd have to re-apply perfume every time she farted in the hallway. It would be pretty obvious to both of them that she'd been hallway farting and perfuming over it.

When Kimber went for her training session, Wayne was already in the conference room with his laptop open sitting in his overly large chair which, combined with his thin mustache, made him look like a bureaucratic overlord.

"Kimber wimber! Let's rip into the good stuff here so we can move you up to a big chair where you belong."

“Sounds good, Wayne. I’m looking forward to it,” said Kimber, as she sank into a small chair with no armrests.

Wayne leaned back in his overlord chair and pressed the spacebar on his laptop.
“Let’s start with one of Oscar’s PlatinumStar packages to break down what works about it, and then we’ll do yours after.”

Kimber felt small in her small chair, picking at her cuticles, aware of how much she was doing it, which made her want to do it more. She wished they’d done the order the opposite way so that her pathetic bomb threat wouldn’t look quite so pathetic after Oscar’s bomb threat, more like the opening act for a clearly superior bomb threat; not a bad bomb threat on its own, just a bomb threat that was learning and growing and you shouldn’t quit on it because someday it’ll be just as good a bomb threat as Oscar’s bomb threats, plus her bomb threats would bring donuts to the breakroom sometimes and Oscar’s wouldn’t.

A police dispatch woman answered the phone on the recording. Oscar’s gravelly baritone went right to business.

“Now you listen to me, Bitch!”

Wayne paused the recording. “See what Oscar did there in that opener?”

Kimber pulled her finger out of her mouth and nodded. “He called her a bitch.”

“Nooo. Well, yes, he did call her a bitch. But the important thing he did was seize the *onus*. Listen to MEEE. Hear the onus there?” Wayne asked.

“He gave her the onus.”

“No,” Wayne explained. “If you give them the onus, then they have the onus, and you don’t.”

Kimber took her pen out of her mouth, clawing against the impulse to make a joke about how onus sounds like anus, then scribbled quick lines in her notebook.

-Call her a bitch.

- Yell MEEE!

-Steal the onus.

Oscar's recording resumed. *"...There's bombs in the Sandalwood Medical Office Complex, so you better not let anybody go to the dentist between 11:AM and 2:30 PM today, or I'm gonna make em go poof, and disappear! Don't fill any cavities this afternoon, or I'll blow everybody's fuckin teeth out of their mouths for you, free of charge. Your move, bitch!"*

Wayne paused the recording, then swiveled in his chair.

"Wow. Classic Oscar. He's an artist. And he always signs his masterpieces at the end with his tagline," said Wayne. "Your Move, Bitch! He's magnificent. You can always tell the great ones from their tagline."

Kimber had to admit, it was a very good bomb threat. "I still gotta figure out my tagline. I'm afraid that if I try a tagline, that's gonna be what everybody expects from all my bomb threats. They're gonna expect me to say the thing, and that's all I'll be, and I dunno, at this stage of my creative development... I just... I don't know who I am as an artist yet, to know what my tagline should be, so I'm afraid that if I did one now, it might be bad, and I'd be stuck with it. Does that make any sense?"

Wayne nodded with fervor. "Nothing has ever made more sense than that, Kimber.

We're a company of artists, creative minds coalescing, being true to our core vision, threatening to blow places up, innovating. And we need you right beside us in a big chair, adding your powerful feminine energy to our creative forcefield."

Kimber smiled with her teeth, scooching her body around awkwardly in her chair. Wayne leaned back. "Alrighty-O. How bout we pop your tape in and break it down?" He asked.

"Let me run into the hallway for a second."

Kimber's breath quickened when she re-entered the training room, drenched in perfume, and heard the sound of her own voice already playing on the recording, so craggy and dry that she could practically hear the Fig Newton crumbs blowing through Wayne's laptop speaker.

"...So, let me have a look here...Yup... Did you say something? Oh, I thought you did...Ok, just to summarize...There is a... Bomb...In... The Summerdale Performing Arts Center...Set to explode during the ballet recital tonight...Yup, the Nutcracker...I know, it's a bummer, I love the Nutcracker, but... Um... You have to cancel it, or everybody will die. So... Yup, I guess that's it... No, I think I told you everything... Nope, don't know where the bomb is, but it's definitely there... Ok...Ok... Thank you, have a nice day!"

Kimber looked at Wayne's Adams apple, waiting for it to waggle and tell her in his very nice way why her bomb threat was terrible, despite how much they'd like her to not be terrible, so they'd have a woman that wasn't terrible, and how invested they seem to be in helping her

not be terrible. She just wanted to take her notebook and run down the hallway and fart a million times and get her purse and her Fig Newtons and leave and never come back.

“So, what did you do wrong there at the end?” Wayne asked.

“I thanked her,” Kimber answered, shrinking into her chair.

“You thanked her,” Wayne repeated, nodding. “You never thank them. That’s the spot for a sizzling catch phrase, like, I don’t know I’m just spit-balling here, but like a ‘We’ll see who’s laughing when I blow you all up!’ or a ‘Any second now, you’re all gonna pay!’ that leaves them going home afraid. The sendoff is so important, because---- Kimber--- are you ok?” She couldn’t look at Wayne’s Adams apple anymore, couldn’t breathe right, couldn’t listen, couldn’t think. A distant paralysis that felt like it had been lurking for weeks enveloped her. She wanted to yell, although there was no reason to yell. She talked very quietly, with a lot of restraint on the volume knob in her throat because she was afraid if she let go of the throttle, words would explode out of her like a shaken root beer.

“Wayne...this thing that’s been happening with the prank calls we’ve been getting... it’s not a big deal, and I know I’m supposed to be a big strong professional person to have a big chair, but it’s been happening more often lately, and it just makes me feel---”

Wayne got out of his overlord chair and crouched below her.

“Heyyy now, Kimber. What’s going on? You can tell me anything. You know we all think that you’re a superduperstar.”

Head down, pressure building in her eyes and stomach, all Kimber could see was Wayne’s ankles. He was making shushing noises like she was a baby, about to cry, but she wasn’t

a baby, and she wasn't about to cry. She was about to yell and start running, but she had nowhere to run to, so she spoke quietly.

"When I get these calls, and they say these... violent things to me on the phone...and they threaten to... blow me up and stuff... I know they're not actually going to do it, but it's the not knowing that stays with me. Not knowing who they are, or why they call, not knowing anything and living all the time with the chance that they might blow me up, or that the phone is gonna ring, and it's gonna be them... all the time I feel, like... I don't know how I feel but I can't feel that way anymore."

She looked at Wayne, waiting for the *"we're the ones who make the bomb threats, not the ones who take the bomb threats! It's all part of earning your big chair!"* pep talk, but he didn't do that. Wayne reached out and pulled Kimber's head into his bony chest as he patted her on the back. He smelled like ranch dressing.

"Heyyy now. You have nothing to worry about. Next time you get a call like that, you tell me, ok? Put them on speakerphone, and I'll give them a talking to."

Kimber was leaning on the wall outside of Oscar's office, eavesdropping through the door on one of his GoldStar package calls.

"You hear that sound, bitch?" Oscar growled. His cold voice made Kimber shudder.
"That's time ticking on you. Tic. Tic. Tic."

Someone tapped Kimber on the shoulder. She screamed and jumped back.

Bill from Billings was standing sheepishly in front of her with his hands behind his back. He was tall and boxy and wore old man cologne. Oscar glared at them through the window to his office, pointing at himself talking on the phone.

"I'm sorry, Kimber," said Bill from Billings, shuffling his feet. "I didn't mean to startle you."

"It's fine. I was just..."

"He's the best, isn't he?" said Bill from Billings, nodding towards Oscar. Kimber turned her head and adjusted her sweater. "Is there something I can help you with, Bill?"

Bill from Billings leaned back on his heels. "I don't need anything, I just..." He took his hands from behind his back and passed a full pack of Fig Newtons to Kimber. "I've seen you eating these and thought it might be nice if I got some for you."

Kimber looked at the Fig Newtons, then back up at Bill from Billings. He looked like the Old Man and the Sea, minus the sea, and his cologne reminded her of a discount shoe store.

"Did you buy me Fig Newtons to make up for tattling to Wayne about the joke?"

"Well, you have me there," said Bill from Billings, chuckling and staring at the floor. "I felt bad about that whole thing. I just wanted you to know that you're doing a great job, and everybody here thinks that you're terrific."

"I can buy my own Fig Newtons, Bill."

Bill from Billings smacked his lips. "Alrighty...well. I'm sorry for making the effort then, I guess." He tried to grab the Fig Newtons, but Kimber held them tight.

He gave her a puzzled glance, then shrugged and waddled down the hallway.

Kimber looked at her reflection in the sheen of Oscar's window and smiled. On the way back to her desk, she threw the Fig Newtons in the garbage.

Several days went by without any bad calls coming, just more orders for fake bomb threats. Fake bombs at schools. Fake bombs at factories. Delivery drivers who kept getting lost in the office complex, which, to be fair, was numbered illogically in a way that frequently caused confusion. Fake bombs at illogically numbered office complexes. Fake bombs at the courthouse, at the post office, at sporting events. She played minesweeper very carefully, avoiding the risky clicks, but every second of every day in the back of her mind she knew the next bad call was coming.

"Fake Bomb Threats, this is Kimber, how may I help you?"

She recognized the voice as soon as it spoke from the previous calls, all throaty and cruel.

"Here's the skinny, you dumb whore. There's a bomb in your little Fake Bomb Threats office, a real bomb, and you better---"

"WAYNE!" Kimber called out. Wayne immediately came running down the hallway. Kimber could barely hear the bomb threat on the phone over the *thwack* of his sandal bottoms smacking the carpet in the hallway. She pressed the speakerphone button.

"---We're serious this time. You think we wouldn't blow you to pieces? Dream on, slut. We're not like you, we don't play around with sissy little bomb threats that are never gonna

happen, so believe me when I say that if you don't quit making fake bomb threats, then you, and everybody in your whole piece of shit company could all fit in the same sardine can after we're done with you. Are you listening to me?"

Wayne leaned over to talk into the speakerphone, but Kimber put her hand in front of him. She didn't know what she was doing, she didn't think, she didn't obsess, she just stood up and let it all out.

"No! Now you listen to MEEE, you little prepubescent ass bitch! You don't sound scary, calling my desk and talking down to me... You think this is a joke? This is real life. Real live crazy people work here, and we track all your dumb prank calls. One of these days when you least expect it, we're gonna follow you home to your mom's house in your rinkydink car, you'll see headlights in your rear-view mirror. Know who that is? That's MEEE, bitch! And when you least expect it, you'll be sitting there playing video games with children on the internet, which is clearly where you learn all your tacky catchphrases. You won't know it's coming. You won't know I'm there, lurking behind you, and I'll jam a hook under your chin, and I'll crank you open like a Pez dispenser, and slit your throat, and I'll rip your eyes out of their sockets and put them on the tv stand and turn them to face you so as you're bleeding out, you can watch me take a shit down your neck! If you ever call here again, it's fucking on. Do you understand? I don't care about all this bomb stuff. This is just my job. In my personal life, I will take pleasure in tearing you to fucking pieces. Think I'm kidding? Call here again and find out."

The voice didn't respond. Wayne hovered, slack jawed. Kimber stared at the phone with a blank look on her face. Then she remembered something.

"Oh, I almost forgot...THANK YOU! HAVE A NICE DAY!"

Kimber slammed the phone down on the receiver, let out a quick yelp sound, then put her hands on her hips to catch her breath. Oscar and Bill from Billings had come to see what all the yelling was about. Wayne didn't say anything. Nobody said anything.

After a pause, Wayne started clapping. Oscar and Bill from Billings started clapping too. "Our little superduperstar!" said Wayne, patting Kimber on the back. "I knew we were getting somewhere with the training!"

Kimber smiled, because she was dizzy and people were clapping and saying nice things to her, but she didn't feel like a star. She felt like...she didn't know what she felt like, she felt like she hadn't been breathing properly for weeks and it was all coming out at once. She was overheating in her sweater, and she felt a very strong urge to rip it off, but she couldn't, so she bolted down the hallway. Everything was getting tighter like the whole office was this ball of shrink-wrap that was heating up, tangling around itself so she'd never be able to leave. She'd have to be a superduperstar there forever in a gigantic chair, eating Fig Newton packs, not even individual Fig Newtons anymore, she'd have to eat the entire pack, plastic packaging and all, farting in the hallway for the rest of her life, never losing at minesweeper, phones ringing all the time, with nobody on the other end. Kimber raced down the hallway, skidded around the corner to the bathroom, flung the toilet seat open, and threw up everywhere.